

Application of LLL for broke instance of ECDSA

Edoardo Torrini

May 2026

1 Elliptic Curve Digital Signature Algorithm (ECDSA)

ECDSA domain parameters

Define Elliptic Curve E defined over $\mathbb{Z}_p$ (es. **P-256**¹), with $n = \#E(\mathbb{Z}_p)$ where n is the order group and a prime number.

A generator $P \in E(\mathbb{Z}_p)$ and a **collision-resistance hash function** H whose output has the same **bitlength** as n (es. $H = \text{SHA256}$)

ECDSA key generation

Alice does:

1. select $a \in_R [1, n - 1]$ and compute $A = aP$.
2. Alice's **public key** is A ; her **private key** is a

Note: computing a from A is an instance of the **ECDLP**.

ECDSA signature generation

To sign a message $M = \{0, 1\}^*$, Alice does:

1. compute $m = H(M)$ and convert m as an integer.
2. select a **ephemeral key per-message secret** $k \in_R [1, n - 1]$.
3. compute $R = kP$. Let $r = x(R) \pmod{n}$, and check that $r \neq 0$ ($x(R)$ is the x-coordinate of R).
4. compute $s = k^{-1}(m + ar) \pmod{n}$ and check that $s \neq 0$.
5. Alice signature is (M, r, s) .

ECDSA verify signature

Bob knows the $(A, M, (r, s))$ and does:

1. verify that r and s are integers in $[1, n - 1]$. If not the signature is **invalid**.
2. compute $m = H(M)$, where H is the same hash function used in the signature generation.
3. calculate $u_1 = zs^{-1} \pmod{n}$ and $u_2 = rs^{-1} \pmod{n}$.
4. compute the curve point $(x_1, y_1) = u_1 \times P + u_2 \times A$ if $(x_1, y_1) = \mathcal{O}$ then the signature is **invalid**.
5. the signature is **valid** if $r \equiv x_1 \pmod{n}$.

Note: an efficient implementation would compute inverse $s^{-1} \pmod{n}$ only once. Also, using Shamir's trick, a sum of two scalar multiplications $u_1 \times P + u_2 \times A$ can be calculated faster than two scalar multiplications done independently².

¹<https://std.neuromancer.sk/nist/P-256>

²https://www.lirmm.fr/~imbert/talks/laurent_Asilomar_08.pdf

2 Cryptanalyze ECDSA using LLL application

LLL is a very powerful cryptanalytic tool, and can be used to break ECDSA with partial information. The general methodology is:

1. define a lattice L in such way that the solution to the cryptanalytic problem is encoded in a nonzero lattice vector v of unusually small length.
2. run LLL algorithm to find a short basis B for L .
3. check whether v is in B .

In the ECDSA signature scheme, a signer has: a **long-term private key a** and a **per-message secret k** . Both must be generated *uniformly at random* from the private key space.

Is possible that some per-message secrets might be leaked during the signing process via a **side-channel attack**: poor implementation, weak random number generator, timing analysis, electromagnetic radiation analysis, etc. This side-channel information can sometimes be used to compute the long-term private key a .

2.1 Leakage: two signatures

Consider the scenario where partial information is leaked about the per-message secret for *two* signed messages. The knowledge of a signed message (M, r, s) yields a linear congruence in two unknowns: **$ks \equiv m + ar \pmod{n}$** . Suppose that an adversary obtains two signed messages (M_1, r_1, s_1) and (M_2, r_2, s_2) . This yields two linear congruences:

$$\begin{aligned} k_1 s_1 &\equiv m_1 + ar_1 \pmod{n} & k_2 s_2 &\equiv m_2 + ar_2 \pmod{n} \\ (k_1 s_1 - m_1) r_1^{-1} &\equiv a \pmod{n} & (k_2 s_2 - m_2) r_2^{-1} &\equiv a \pmod{n} \end{aligned}$$

Solving for a and equating return the congruence:

$$\begin{aligned} (k_1 s_1 - m_1) r_1^{-1} &\equiv (k_2 s_2 - m_2) r_2^{-1} \pmod{n} \\ (k_1 s_1 - m_1) r_2 &\equiv (k_2 s_2 - m_2) r_1 \pmod{n} \end{aligned}$$

Rearranging gives the **linear congruence**: **$k_1 - (s_1 r_2)^{-1} s_2 r_1 k_2 + (s_1 r_2)^{-1} (m_2 r_1 - m_1 r_2) \equiv 0 \pmod{n}$** where the only quantities that are not known to the adversary are k_1 and k_2 . One linear congruence in two unknowns does not usually sufficient to recover k_1 and k_2 . However it might be possible to solve k_1 and k_2 if the attacker already has substantial partial information about k_1 and k_2 . For example an upperbound on their size. If the adversary can solve for k_1 and k_2 , they immediately recover the long-term key a and thus the ECDSA instance is completely broken.

Let's assume that $k_1, k_2 \leq K$, where $K \ll n$. Is possible to rewrite the congruence as **$k_1 + tk_2 + u \equiv 0 \pmod{n}$** where $t = -(s_1 r_2)^{-1} s_2 r_1 \pmod{n}$ and $u = (s_1 r_2)^{-1} (m_2 r_1 - m_1 r_2) \pmod{n}$. Is possible to convert the congruence into the equation:

$$k_1 + tk_2 + hn + u = 0 \tag{1}$$

where $h \in \mathbb{Z}$. The adversary can compute t and u , and knows n .

Consider the lattice L with basis vectors **$(n, 0, 0)$, $(t, 1, K)$ and $(u, 0, K)$** . The basis matrix for L is:

$$B = \begin{bmatrix} n & t & u \\ 0 & 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & K \end{bmatrix}$$

so the volume of L is $\text{vol}(L) = nK$. Note that:

$$v = B[h, k_2, 1]^T = \begin{bmatrix} n & t & u \\ 0 & 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & K \end{bmatrix} \begin{bmatrix} x \\ k_2 \\ 1 \end{bmatrix} = \begin{bmatrix} hn + tk_2 + u \\ k_2 \\ K \end{bmatrix}$$

Compute row by row:

- Row 1: $n \cdot x + t \cdot k_2 + u \cdot 1 = nx + tk_2 + u$
- Row 2: $0 \cdot x + 1 \cdot k_2 + 0 \cdot 1 = k_2$
- Row 3: $0 \cdot x + 0 \cdot k_2 + K \cdot K = K$

We obtain the vector $v = [tk_2 + hn + u, k_2, K]^T$ if we use the equation 1 we can substitute the $tk_2 + hn + u$ with the terms $-k_1$ so it is possible to obtain the vector $[-k_1, k_2, K]$.

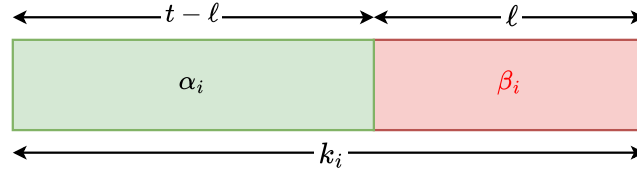
This lattice vector has length $\|v\| = \sqrt{k_1^2 + k_2^2 + K^2} \leq \sqrt{3K^2} = \sqrt{3}K$. The *Gaussian heuristic* asserts that $\lambda_1(L) \approx \sqrt{3/2\pi e}(\text{vol}(L))^{1/3} \approx (nK)^{1/3}$. So, if $\|v\| \ll (nK)^{1/3}$, we can expect that v is a shortest nonzero vector in L . In this event, the adversary can (likely) determine v by solving SVP in L . Knowledge of v immediately reveals k_1 and k_2 , and then the long-term private key a can be efficiently computed from the signing equation.

This requirements is satisfied if more than half of the leftmost bits of each per-message secret are known to be zero.

2.2 Leakage: many signature

Let's now turn to a more realistic scenario in which only few bits of each per message secret are leaked. For concreteness, we will consider the scenario those leaked bits are least significant bits. However the attack can be adapted just as easily if the leaked information where most significant bits or even some middle portion.

Suppose now that the adversary has obtain: N signed messages (M_i, r_i, s_i) where $i \in \mathbb{N}_N$, and a few least significant bits of each per-message secret k_i .



Define $k_i = \alpha_i \cdot 2^\ell + \beta_i$ where $\beta_i < 2^\ell$. The idea is that the adversary knows only β_i , but not α_i . In this scenario we define $K = \lceil n/2^\ell \rceil$, in that way $\alpha_i < K$. Is possible to compose a system of linear congruences, where each congruence is similar to the equation 1 substituting the k_1 with k_i where $i \in [1, 2, \dots, N-1]$ and the k_2 with the K_N . In that way is possible to obtain a congruence like: $k_i + t'_i k_N + u'_i \equiv 0 \pmod{n}$ next for each equation replace each k_i by $\alpha_i 2^\ell + \beta_i$, multiply both sides by $2^{-\ell} \pmod{n}$, simplify, and eliminate the “ $\pmod{n}$ ”. To obtain:

$$\begin{aligned}
 k_i + t'_i k_N + u'_i &\equiv 0 \pmod{n} \\
 (\alpha_i 2^\ell + \beta_i) + t'_i (\alpha_N 2^\ell + \beta_N) + u'_i &\equiv 0 \pmod{n} \\
 \alpha_i + \underbrace{\beta_i 2^{-\ell}}_{\text{known}} + t'_i \alpha_N + \underbrace{t'_i \beta_N 2^{-\ell}}_{\text{known}} + \underbrace{u'_i 2^{-\ell}}_{\text{known}} &\equiv 0 \pmod{0} \\
 \alpha_i + t_i \alpha_N + u_i &\equiv 0 \pmod{n} \\
 \alpha_i + t_i \alpha_N + u_i + h_i n &= 0
 \end{aligned} \tag{2}$$

Where $t_i = t'_i$ and $u_i = (\beta_i + t'_i \beta_N + u'_i) \cdot 2^{-\ell} \pmod{n}$. In that way we have $N-1$ equations $\alpha_i + t_i \alpha_N + h_i n + u_i = 0$, where the unknown quantities are α_i, h_i for $i \in \mathbb{N}_N$. Now, consider the $(N+1)$ -dimensional integer lattice $L \subseteq \mathbb{Z}^{N+1}$ with basis matrix:

$$B = \begin{bmatrix} n & 0 & \cdots & 0 & t_1 & u_1 \\ 0 & n & \cdots & 0 & t_2 & u_2 \\ \vdots & \vdots & \ddots & \vdots & \vdots & \vdots \\ 0 & 0 & \cdots & n & t_{N-1} & u_{N-1} \\ 0 & 0 & \cdots & 0 & 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & \cdots & 0 & 0 & K \end{bmatrix}_{(N+1) \times (N+1)}$$

The B matrix is an **upper triangular matrix** so its determinant which is also the volume of the lattice can be seen to be $\text{vol}(L) = n^{N-1}K$. Note that $v = B[h_1, h_2, \dots, h_{N-1}, \alpha_N, 1]^T = (-\alpha_1, -\alpha_2, \dots, -\alpha_{N-1}, -\alpha_N, K) \in L$ is a lattice vector of length $\|v\| = \sqrt{\alpha_1^2 + \dots + \alpha_N^2 + K^2} \leq \sqrt{N+1}K^2 \approx \sqrt{N}K^2$.

Example with $N = 6$

$$\begin{pmatrix} n & 0 & 0 & 0 & 0 & t_1 & u_1 \\ 0 & n & 0 & 0 & 0 & t_2 & u_2 \\ 0 & 0 & n & 0 & 0 & t_3 & u_3 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & n & 0 & t_4 & u_4 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 0 & n & t_5 & u_5 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 0 & 0 & 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 0 & 0 & 0 & K \end{pmatrix} \times \begin{pmatrix} h_1 \\ h_2 \\ h_3 \\ h_4 \\ h_5 \\ \alpha_6 \\ 1 \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} nh_1 + t_1\alpha_6 + u_1 \\ nh_2 + t_2\alpha_6 + u_2 \\ nh_3 + t_3\alpha_6 + u_3 \\ nh_4 + t_4\alpha_6 + u_4 \\ nh_5 + t_5\alpha_6 + u_5 \\ \alpha_6 \\ K \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} -\alpha_1 \\ -\alpha_2 \\ -\alpha_3 \\ -\alpha_4 \\ -\alpha_5 \\ \alpha_6 \\ K \end{pmatrix} \quad (3)$$

The *Gaussian heuristic* asserts that:

$$\begin{aligned} \lambda_1(L) &\approx \sqrt{(N+1)/2\pi e} (\text{vol}(L))^{1/(N+1)} \\ &\approx N^{1/2} (n^{N-1} K)^{1/(N+1)} \\ &= N^{1/2} n^{(N+1)/(N+1)} K^{1/(N+1)} \end{aligned}$$

We desire that $\|v\|$ is significantly shorter than the above estimate for $\lambda_1(L)$, so $N^{\frac{1}{2}}K \ll N^{\frac{1}{2}}n^{\frac{N-1}{N+1}}K^{\frac{1}{N+1}}$ can be simplify to $K^N \ll n^{N-1}$. Let $t = \lceil \log_2 n \rceil$ the bit length of the modulus n , whence $\log_2 K \approx t - \ell$ (the bit length of the unknown part of the per-message secret).

The inequality $K^N \ll n^{N-1}$ simplifies to $N(t - \ell) \ll Nt - t$, which yield $N \gg \frac{t}{\ell}$. If this condition is fulfilled the adversary can (likely) determine v by solving the SVP in L . Some experiments have shown that the attack is successful for ℓ as small as 2. The attack can be adopted to situations where the adversary learns a few *most significant bits* of the per-message secrets, or a few *middle bits* of per-message secrets.

The attack has been effective in breaking poor implementations of ECDSA in practice, including in Bitcoin applications.

Some example of this attack's type are available on my Github³

³https://github.com/EdoardoTorrini/post_quantum_cryptography